

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Nonprofit and NGO English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

advocacy

Communication or action intended to influence decisions on an issue.

attribution

Assigning a result or contribution to a particular source, activity, or cause.

baseline

A defined starting value or agreed reference used to measure change.

board governance

The structures and practices through which a board directs and oversees an organization.

campaign

A coordinated set of activities intended to achieve a communication or marketing objective.

cash runway

An estimate of how long available cash will last under stated spending assumptions.

community trust

Confidence that an organization will act reliably and respectfully toward a community.

confidentiality

Protecting information from disclosure to people who are not authorized to receive it.

contingency

A possible future condition or provision for it; in contracts, a condition affecting the transaction.

deliverable

A specified item of work to be provided to a customer or project recipient.

dignity

Respect for a person's worth, agency, and privacy.

duty of care

A responsibility to exercise appropriate care toward people affected by one's actions.

field visit

A visit to a project or service location to observe work and meet relevant people.

grant proposal

An application explaining proposed work, intended outcomes, and funding needs.

implementing partner

An organization responsible for delivering agreed program activities.

incident report

A structured record of an event, available facts, and relevant follow-up information.

indicator

A defined measure or observation used to assess a condition or change.

learning agenda

A set of questions an organization plans to investigate to improve its work.

mission

An organization's central purpose and intended contribution.

mission fit

How well an activity supports an organization's purpose.

outcome

A change or result achieved, distinguished from the activity delivered.

output

A product or activity delivered by work, such as a report or completed session.

reserve

Resources set aside for a purpose; in insurance, an estimate of amounts needed for obligations.

restricted funding

Money that may be used only for specified purposes or under stated conditions.

safeguarding

Measures and processes intended to protect people from abuse, exploitation, and other harm.

scenario

A description of possible conditions used to explore decisions or practice responses.

source

The origin of information, data, or a claim.

supervision

Oversight and support by a person responsible for directing or checking work.

survivor-centered

An approach that gives priority to a survivor's safety, dignity, preferences, and appropriate support.

theory of change

An explanation of how activities are expected to contribute to outcomes under stated assumptions.

training

Planned instruction and practice to develop a capability.

volunteer role

The agreed tasks, limits, and responsibilities of an unpaid participant.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

02 | Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

A team wants to move grant money to another activity. The award's spending restrictions have not been checked.

Does the grant agreement permit this use, or is approval required? Let's confirm the restrictions with the responsible team before presenting the funds as available for the new activity.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

03 | Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Participant outcomes improved during a program, but no comparison group or alternative explanation has been examined.

The improvement is observed among participants. We cannot attribute all of it to the program from this evidence alone. I'll describe the result and the limits of the evaluation design.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

04 | Field Operations and Partner Coordination

A field partner changes a planned visit date. The community contact has not yet been told and transport is still booked for the original date.

The visit date has changed, but communication and transport updates remain open. Please confirm who will contact the community and revise the booking so the handoff includes the practical consequences.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

05 | Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

A volunteer raises a safeguarding concern. The receiving manager must use the organization's established reporting process and handle the information carefully.

Thank you for raising the concern. I'll help route it through the safeguarding process and explain the next appropriate contact. We should share the information only through the designated channels and avoid investigating informally.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

06 | Volunteer Management and Training

A volunteer is enthusiastic about taking on a task beyond their agreed role and training.

I appreciate your willingness to help. This task needs preparation and supervision that are not part of your current role. Let's identify an appropriate task today and discuss the training needed for more responsibility.

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

07 | Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

A fundraising draft uses an alarming statistic without its source or date. The campaign team wants to publish immediately.

We need the source, date, and context before using this statistic. Could we verify what it measures and choose wording that accurately represents the people and situation described?

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

08 | Board Reporting and Sustainability

A board considers using reserves or reducing program activity during a funding gap. Some funds are restricted.

The options have different effects on services and future flexibility. Let's distinguish unrestricted reserves from restricted funds and compare the program implications before the board makes a decision.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.